NAPOLEONIC WARS

SANTO DOMINGO

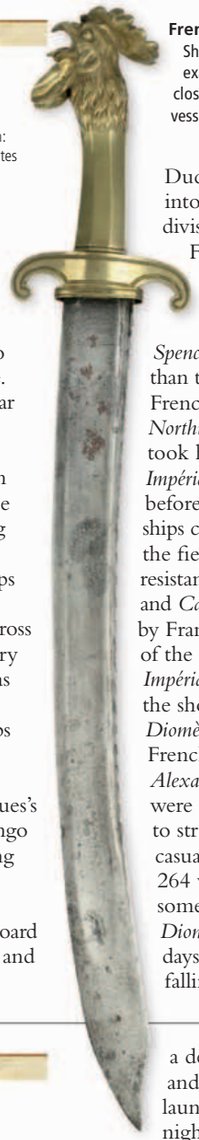


Date February 6, 1806
Forces British: 7 ships of the line, 2 frigates; French: 5 ships of the line, 2 frigates
Losses British: none; French: 2 ships wrecked, 3 captured

Location Off Santo Domingo, Dominican Republic

On December 13, 1805, the best part of the French fleet at Brest profited from bad weather to slip past the British close blockade. One squadron, commanded by Rear Admiral Leissegues on board the magnificent 130-gun *Impérial*, had orders to sail to Santo Domingo in the West Indies. A month later, Vice Admiral Duckworth, commanding the British squadron blockading Cadiz, learned that the French ships had been sighted heading for the Caribbean. He promptly set off across the Atlantic in pursuit. On February 1, 1806, Duckworth's squadron was taking on water at St. Kitts when a sloop reported seeing French ships of the line at Santo Domingo.

At daybreak on February 6 the British squadron surprised Leissegues's ships at anchor in the Santo Domingo roads. The French had been making preparations to sail, and although many men were ashore, including Admiral Leissegues, the crews on board were able swiftly to weigh anchor and make a dash for the open sea.

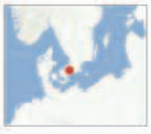


French marine's sword
Short swords, such as this French example, were used by marines in close combat when boarding enemy vessels. Pistols were also carried.

Duckworth formed his ships into windward and leeward divisions and raced to bar the French escape. The three ships in the van of the windward line (*Superb*, *Northumberland,* and *Spencer*) made far better speed than the rest and engaged the French in a running battle. *Northumberland* in particular took heavy punishment from *Impérial*'s thundering broadsides, before the rest of the British ships came up and overwhelmed the fierce and stubborn French resistance. Harried by *Superb* and *Canopus* (the latter captained by Francis Austen, the brother of the novelist Jane Austen), *Impérial* deliberately ran on to the shore, as did the 74-gun *Diomède*. The other three French ships of the line, *Alexandre*, *Jupiter,* and *Brave*, were all disabled and obliged to strike their colors. British casualties were 74 killed and 264 wounded; the French lost some 1,500 men. *Impérial* and *Diomède* were burned two days later to prevent them falling into British hands.

NAPOLEONIC WARS

COPENHAGEN



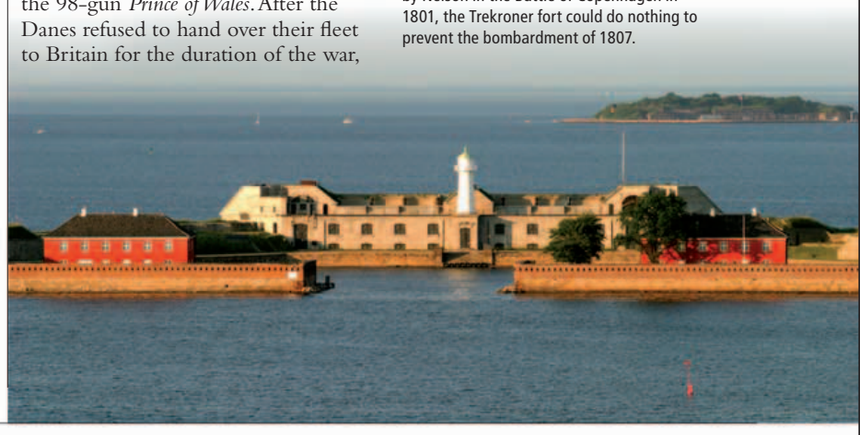
Date September 2–5, 1807
Forces British: 17 ships of the line, 21 frigates
Losses British: none; Danish: 18 ships of the line, 11 frigates surrendered

Location Copenhagen, Denmark

In July 1807 Britain feared that neutral Denmark was about to ally itself with Napoleon, giving France control of the Danish fleet and of the entrance to the Baltic Sea. Such a situation would be intolerable as it would prove ruinous to British trade and block the Royal Navy's access to two of its allies against France—Sweden and Russia. In response, on July 26, a British fleet sailed from Yarmouth for Copenhagen under Admiral James Gambier aboard the 98-gun *Prince of Wales*. After the Danes refused to hand over their fleet to Britain for the duration of the war, British troops landed and laid siege to Copenhagen, while the warships stayed out of range of shore batteries.

On the night of September 2, Gambier began a bombardment of the city to intimidate the population into surrender. Newly introduced Congreve rockets were among the weapons used to rain destruction upon the Danes. An eyewitness in the city described how "bombs, grenades, fireballs … rockets and shells flew about our ears." The bombing continued for three nights, flattening a third of Copenhagen and killing thousands of civilians. Powerless to resist, the Danes surrendered both the city and their fleet. Denmark became an ally of France but the British took the Danish ships and were able to maintain access to the Baltic.

Trekroner fort
Part of the formidable coastal defenses faced by Nelson in the Battle of Copenhagen in 1801, the Trekroner fort could do nothing to prevent the bombardment of 1807.



NAPOLEONIC WARS

BASQUE ROADS



Date April 11–13, 1809
Forces British: 11 ships of the line, 1 frigate; French: 11 ships of the line, 4 frigates
Losses British: none; French: 4 ships of the line, 1 frigate

Location Off Rochefort, Bay of Biscay

In February 1809 Admiral Jean-Baptiste Willaumez sailed from Brest with eight ships of the line, eluding the blockading squadron of Admiral James Gambier. Willaumez reached the Rochefort roads, where three more ships awaited him, but delays allowed Gambier to catch him up. Since the British admiral refused to risk his ships in the narrow channels of the roads, and Willaumez would not come out to fight, a stalemate ensued. The aggressive Captain Thomas Cochrane, agitating for more positive action, arranged for himself to be sent from Britain to join Gambier with a score of fireships—a move the admiral did not welcome. In the roads the French were prepared for a fireship attack, anchoring their ships in two lines between the islands of Aix and Oléron, behind a defensive boom of spars and chains. Cochrane launched his attack on the night of April 11. He packed four vessels with explosives and took them in first to blow holes in the boom. The explosions were so spectacular that they completely destroyed French morale. In panic the French captains cut their cables and fled for the safety of the Charente River. In the darkness and confusion many ships collided and all but two of them ran aground. The fireship attack itself proved to be a damp squib, but morning broke to reveal French ships grounded at the mercy of British guns. But Gambier was in no hurry to enter the roads and proceeded with great caution. As a result, seven of the French ships were refloated and escaped upriver. Two ships of the line were destroyed by the British and two were scuttled by their crews.

NAPOLEONIC WARS

GRAND PORT



Date August 23–24, 1810
Forces British: 4 frigates; French: 5 frigates
Losses British: 2 ships destroyed, 2 captured; French: none

Location Grand Port, Mauritius

French frigates based on Mauritius were preying upon British merchant ships crossing the Indian Ocean. In response, in the summer of 1810 British frigates launched an attack on the island's east coast, capturing the Ile de la Passe at the entrance to the lagoon off Grand Port. On August 20, the French frigates *Bellone*, *Minerve,* and *Victor*, under the command of Commodore Guy-Victor Duperré, arrived at Grand Port, unaware of the British presence, and broke through to the lagoon. Three days later, largely on the initiative of Nesbit Willoughby, captain of *Nereide*, the four British frigates sailed into the lagoon to engage the French at anchor. Two of the British ships, *Sirius* and *Magicienne*, quickly ran aground. *Nereide* was left exposed to the full force of the French broadsides. In a static encounter at close range the frigate was reduced to a shambles. Willoughby had an eye torn out of its socket by a splinter. More than 220 of *Nereide*'s 280 crew were killed or wounded before she struck the following morning. The immovable *Magicienne* and *Sirius* were scuttled and the surviving British frigate, *Iphigenia*, was trapped by the arrival of two more French frigates as she made to escape. It was the only defeat of a British squadron during the Napoleonic Wars.



Flintlock swivel gun
This bowsprit swivel gun was mounted on the front of the ship to guard against boarders. It was loaded and fired in the same way as a musket or pistol.